

Playing the suicide game

Sony's multiplayer online role playing game, EverQuest, is addictive. But is it addictive enough for someone to kill himself?

That's what Shawn Woolley's mother wants to find out.

Shawn was a major EverQuest addict who quit his job to play EverQuest full time. The 21-year old shot himself on Thanksgiving last year. Elizabeth Woolley, his mother, believes that his online gaming partners

might have clues as to what happened.

The problems arose when she approached Sony Online



Entertainment (SOE) for details. They refused to give

details citing customer privacy. This has led to Elizabeth suing Sony over Shawn's suicide. She wants Sony to put warning labels on the game. EverQuest has more than 400,000 people playing it online.

Blaming gaming alone for suicide is not an excuse. It's more important that parents monitor what their kids are doing online.

Besides that, correcting poor social skills and mental problems is also important. It's a combination of all these that drive a person towards suicide than just excessive online gaming.

quoteworthy

"I am a big believer in forcing change on large institutions for the sake of forcing change. The longer an organisation stays intact, the less successful it is."

— Louis Gerstner, Chairman and CEO, IBM Corp

"Intellectual property is at risk from rampant bootlegging, file sharing and CD burning."

— Pete Jones, CEO of BMG Distribution

"This is a combination that's good for Linux."

— Carly Fiorina on the HP-Compaq merger

Digital pens to replace keyboards

Think about entering data into a computer and the first thing to pop into your mind is a keyboard. An Israeli company plans to change that with their digital pen which is set to replace keyboards and mice. Virtual

pen or 'Vpen' from OTM Technologies allows mobile and PDA users to enter data, draw images, point and click, and play games. The Vpen is basically a stylus with a tiny optical laser reader. Although this concept has been around from the



1960s, it never really took off.

However, OTM has the advantage with Microsoft, Motorola, Siemens, and others supporting the technology. Motorola has already demonstrated its latest line of mobile phones which work with a wireless OTM pen. Microsoft also showed an iPaq linked to an OTM pen.

snapshot

\$39.7 bn
was spent to acquire
1,289 Internet companies in 2001

Source: Webmergers

tomorrow's technology

Digitally discerning

With the current bandwidth situation in the country, here's a new development that's sure to tickle videoconferencing buffs to the bone. A new technology, recently developed by an Israeli start-up, 3DV Systems, has the potential to make Web-based video a

reality on slow dial-up lines. Their object extraction is a new technique that can discriminate objects in its field



of view and capture only what's required. It uses a laser to gauge depth of items and sends its readings to a computer. Their fellow countrymen at EnQuad Technologies employ a similar software solution.

The company has built an algorithm that can extract objects from a pre-recorded stream of video. It is similar to the Israeli technology in

that it can process the removal of undesired objects in real-time. According to the company's CEO, Eran Yarom, the technology can be stretched to accommodate other uses. A video feed of a cricket match can clearly capture the playing field, while sampling the outfield and the audience in a much lower resolution. Yarom claims the results are outstanding; a 75 per cent drop in bandwidth requirements. India, this one's for you!

■ Microsoft to focus on developing Office suite and IE for Mac ■ Banias to change Intel's mobile road map drastically ■